

Curriculum Vitae **Riccardo Graziani**

PhD Candidate in Economics, VIVES Research Centre, KU Leuven

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Education

- 2023 – 2027 (Planned) **PhD Candidate in Economics**, KU Leuven (VIVES Research Centre)
Promotor: Prof. Dr. Joep Konings
Placement officer: Prof. Dr. Edoardo Ciscato
- 2022 **Master of Science in Economics** (Research Advanced Master), UCLouvain
Joint degree with Bocconi University
- 2022 **Master of Science in Economics and Social Sciences**, Bocconi University
- 2019 **Bachelor of Science in Economics and Social Sciences**, Bocconi University

References

Joep Konings
VIVES Research Centre, KU Leuven
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Working Papers

Who Speaks for the People? Electoral Reforms, Parliamentary Speech, and Legislative Behaviour in Belgium, 1880–1912 (JMP)

with Jakob Vanschoonbeek

Presented at the ‘Text-as-data’ in Economics Workshop, University of Bath (July 2026), and at DiPaDA 2026 (Digital Parliamentary Data in Action), University of Ljubljana (September 2026).

Abstract: Does extending the franchise change what a parliament attends to, and if so, does it work by changing the behaviour of the politicians already in office or by changing who holds office? We study this question in Belgium, which introduced plural male suffrage in 1894 and proportional representation in 1900, using a new dataset that links the plenary interventions of both chambers of parliament between 1880 and 1912 to the speaker’s party and constituency, and to the bills that members introduced. The share of each intervention devoted to labour and social policy is measured by a transformer classifier trained for this corpus and validated against blind human coding. Because its eligibility census prevented working-class candidates from entering the Senate, the difference between the two chambers identifies the Chamber’s differential response to electoral exposure, net of shocks common to both chambers, such as the strikes and unrest that produced the reforms. After enfranchisement, the Chamber’s attention to the social question rose by 4.5 percentage points relative to the Senate’s, on a base of 7.9, everywhere in the country and mainly among sitting deputies. Proportional representation produced no aggregate shift but a large effect in the coalfields, where it reopened seats the majoritarian rule had handed to the socialists. It was driven by the entry of new members. Social bills deposited by Catholic and Liberal members rose after 1894, mostly among Catholics, and again after 1900, among Liberals. Enfranchisement thus raised attention to the social question across the country, while proportional representation restored it in the coalfields through the members it elected. Which channel operated was set by the part of the electoral system each reform changed.

One Reform Divided the Elite, the Other Replaced It: Electoral Reform and Parliamentary Speech in the Belgian Belle Époque, 1880–1912

with Jakob Vanschoonbeek

Abstract: What makes a governing elite pull apart? Explanations of elite polarization emphasize demand-side drivers acting on the electorate, while the electoral institutions that structure competition figure as objects of elite choice rather than as causes of elite behaviour. We ask whether electoral reform can itself divide a governing elite, using two Belgian reforms that fall on opposite sides of that divide: plural manhood suffrage (1894), which reshaped the electorate, and proportional representation (1900), which reshaped how votes become seats. We measure elite polarization directly from parliamentary speech, applying the leave-out partisanship estimator of Gentzkow et al. (2019) to all plenary debates of both houses, 490,002 interventions over three decades. Identification exploits Belgium’s imperfect bicameralism as a difference in exposure: both houses were returned by the same enlarged electorate, but candidacy rules the reforms left untouched kept the new competitor out of the upper house, so the Chamber debated with socialists in it and the Senate did not. Plural suffrage produced a rise

in Catholic–Liberal distinctiveness that is timed to the reform, persistent to the end of the window, and driven by the within-politician adaptation of sitting members rather than by turnover; the divergence is overwhelmingly within-topic, and largest on labour and social policy. Proportional representation did not move that distance. What it moved was the composition of the chamber: the post-1900 divergence loads on entrants rather than on sitting members. Enfranchisement changed how the sitting elite spoke; proportionality changed who was there to speak.

Anti-Revolutionary Roads? The Political Effects of Belgium’s Workmen’s Trains

with Jakob Vanschoonbeek

Abstract: Between 1885 and 1910 Belgium built one of the world’s densest light rail networks, partly as an instrument of political containment: the governing Catholic and Liberal parties hoped that letting workers reach city jobs while living in the countryside would shield them from the rising socialist movement, while the socialists hoped the same connectivity would carry their ideas into the hinterland. Using newly assembled archival data on the network, demography, commuting, and local elections, I develop a quantitative spatial political economy model of location, commuting, and political choices to adjudicate between the two views. Because the political effect runs partly through the endogenous reallocation of the electorate, I identify it from the unexpected component of light-rail-induced gains in job market access and show that the network moved location and commuting alone, leaving wages and rents unchanged. It modestly tempered urbanisation, lowering agglomeration populations by up to two per cent, yet raised socialist vote shares where access improved most. Aggregated through the D’Hondt seat allocation rule, the network accounts for three parliamentary seats that passed to the left rather than the Catholics, slimming the governing majority from a counterfactual thirteen seats to seven. The incumbents’ counter-revolutionary instrument, in short, modestly hastened the rise it was built to forestall.

Data Papers

The Belgian Chamber Debates Dataset: Speeches, Roll-Call Votes and Member Biographies, 1831–2025

Abstract: In this Data Descriptor, we introduce a dataset on the plenary speeches of the Belgian Chamber of Representatives and the background characteristics of the members who speak in it. The database includes all plenary speeches from the first sitting of the Chamber, in 1831, to the end of 2025, linked to the members and ministers who delivered them, together with the roll-call votes cast in the same sittings. These data have been used in previous studies to analyze how plural voting and proportional representation changed what the Chamber talked about and how far apart its parties spoke. The long time period, from census suffrage to the federal state, makes it possible to study how historical changes are reflected in parliamentary speeches.

Selected Work in Progress

Partisanship in Belgian Parliamentary Speech: Evidence from the Chamber of Representatives, 1831–2025

Abstract: How have divisions between Belgian parties changed over time? How did they respond to wider voting rights, proportional representation and the split of national parties along linguistic lines? We measure partisanship in speeches in the Belgian Chamber of Representatives from its first sitting in 1831 to 2025. We use the measure developed for the US Congress by Gentzkow et al. (2019): the expected posterior probability that a neutral observer assigns to a speaker’s actual party after hearing a single phrase. Partisanship between Catholics and other parties is low under census suffrage, rises when the Socialists enter the Chamber in 1894 and peaks in the 1950s, during the Royal Question and the second school war. At that peak, an observer hearing one minute of speech would identify a member’s party correctly with probability 0.69. Partisanship falls sharply after the School Pact of 1958. Partisanship between the left and other parties peaks in 1894, the early 1930s, the 1950s and the mid-1970s, and is lowest in the federal era. Both series peak when these divisions align with the divide between government and opposition. This is the most persistent division in speech. Parties differ in how they govern and oppose, as well as in how they discuss schools, social policy and the monarchy. Catholics and Liberals differed most during the second school war. Catholics and Socialists were the most distant pair, while Liberals and Socialists converged whenever they governed together. Before the national parties split, Flemish and Walloon members differed mainly in their regional agendas, with no widening gap in their speech. Belgian partisanship peaked earlier than in other parliaments studied with this method and has remained below its historical levels.

Research Experience

2019 – 2023

Research Assistant, Harvard Business School
for James M. Snyder and Marco Tabellini

- Python and Stata pipelines for large-scale historical data construction, using OCR and web scraping
- Unsupervised learning and sentiment analysis on large collections of political texts

2020 – 2023

Research Assistant, University of Rome Tor Vergata
for Stefano Gagliarducci

- Electoral and administrative data to study the impact of COVID-19 policies on electoral outcomes in Italy
- Gravity models estimated with high-dimensional fixed-effects regressions

Research Interest

PRIMARY	Political Economy, Economic History, Urban Economics
SECONDARY	Text as Data, Democratization and Representation, Political Polarization, Transport Networks

Technical and Language Skills

Programming	Python, Stata, R, C++, Matlab
Methods	Causal inference (difference-in-differences, instrumental variables), panel data, gravity models; machine learning, natural language processing, text classification; web scraping and OCR
Software	L ^A T _E X, ArcGIS, ABBYY FineReader
Languages	Italian (Native), English (Fluent), French (Intermediate), Spanish (Intermediate)

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